

CARTESIAN STUDIES

LEON ROTH

1

AN interesting book could be written on the varying interpretation which have been given to this one or that of the great philosophers. If it be true that the history of European thought consists of footnotes to Plato, it is no less true that the footnotes, and thus the Plato, are in every epoch different. Kant was claimed by different followers for both Realism and Idealism, Hegel for both Right and Left. It would be difficult to present Hume as a believer, but many believers have based themselves on Hume. Spinoza remains 'atheistic' to some, 'God-intoxicated' to others, epithets which, whatever their meaning, attach themselves perhaps more justly to the outlooks and persons of their users. So true it is that the knowledge we have of things reflects our own nature rather than the nature of the things known.

A more moderate case of re-interpretation lies now before us in Professor Norman Kemp Smith's *New Studies in the Philosophy of Descartes*. The title of the book deserves comment. It harks back to the same author's *Studies in the Cartesian Philosophy* published as long ago as 1902. In the half-century intervening Professor Kemp Smith has found time to do other things besides studying Descartes. He has offered his own original account of some fundamental metaphysical problems; he has translated, and commented extensively on, Kant; he has rescued from neglect Hume's *Dialogues on Natural Religion* and produced a massive volume on Hume's philosophy. In returning now to his first interest he returns enriched by a wide and profound experience of the whole gamut of modern philosophy in its patient and detailed interpretation. His conclusions, therefore, paradoxical as they may seem, deserve the closest attention.

2

René Descartes, born towards the end of the sixteenth century, died just over three hundred years ago when within a few weeks of his fifty-fourth year. His first published work, the *Discourse on Method and Essays in the Method* (1637), was followed by the *Meditations* (1641), the *Principles of Philosophy* (1644) and a work on what would be now called psychology (the *Passions of the Soul*, 1649). In the *Meditations*, as is attested by its sub-title, he undertook to demonstrate the existence of God and the immortality of the soul. In order to do this he departed from the accepted philosophical tradition and made a fresh start. Instead of proceeding from

nature as effect to God as cause, he argued that the idea of God involved his existence; and he confuted the sceptics not by indicating the weakness of their positions but by pointing out that complete scepticism is impossible since existence must be allowed at least to the sceptic. Further, he insisted on the irreducible distinction between mind and matter, and he equated matter with figured space. On the ground of these seeming novelties with their startling and far-reaching consequences he was acclaimed by later generations as a great innovator, indeed as the very 'father of modern philosophy'. His principle: 'I think, hence I am', his use of the ontological argument for the existence of God, his cleansing of mind of any admixture of matter, made him the inspirer of a whole stream of thought which is still best summed up as the Philosophy of Spirit. He stands at the head of the long line of thinkers who see in self-consciousness the key to the comprehension both of the human and of the divine.

3

The account just given remains that generally taught and may fairly be called the official one. Its shape was determined by Hegel's chapter in his penetrating and all-influential *Lectures on the History of Philosophy*, and in its classic form it may be studied by English readers in Edward Caird's *Britannica* article on Cartesianism reprinted in his *Essays on Literature and Philosophy* (1892). So too in France, although specialists like the collaborators in Lalande's classic *Vocabulaire technique et critique de la philosophie* refused to authorize an article setting out the theses of Cartesianism because they could not agree on the thinkers, or the exact nature of the doctrine, which could properly be called Cartesian. In common literary parlance Cartesianism is known and recognized, in the words of a recent French critic, as 'la philosophie de l'esprit pur'.

Yet Descartes' own contemporaries did not understand him thus; nor indeed did Descartes himself. As one turns over his correspondence — and correspondence in those days took the place of the discussions of a modern learned review — one sees Descartes striving to win recognition not so much for his metaphysics, i.e. his account of God and the soul, as for his physics, his account of external nature; while his critics dismissed physics and metaphysics alike, saying that the one was not true and the other not new.

Both criticisms seem to have been just. The former was endorsed by the progress of science (Newton's *Principia* appeared in 1687); the latter by recent literary investigation. Jacob Freudenthal pointed out in another connection how thoroughly impregnated Descartes was with the vocabulary of Scholasticism. The hint was worked out by M. Etienne Gilson, who in a series of books astonishing for

their wealth of learning and width of range gave chapter and verse for Descartes' dependence on, and retention of, the tradition he was generally supposed either to have been ignorant of or to have destroyed. It would seem that there is not an idea, indeed hardly a word, in Descartes' writings which has not its analogue in the writings of the Schoolmen, understanding by that name, together with Aquinas himself, the numerous writers of kindred types of thought up to and including Descartes' own day. Descartes' originality at least would seem to have been over-estimated. He used a historic terminology and could not escape entanglement in its content and implications. And this was true not only for his theology which appears as an amended Thomism but also in many respects, and even more surprisingly, for his physics too.

There are however other, and philosophically more important, considerations. The accepted account of Descartes centred round the *Meditations*, that is, the metaphysics and the doctrine of God and mind. But there were other writings too, and among them must be reckoned a short and unfinished work on logic, published, together with other fragments, not by the author himself but fifty years after his death from his manuscript, under the title 'Rules for the Direction of the Human Mind' (commonly known as the *Regulae*). This had been neglected by the historians but it seemed important, especially when it was suspected as having been circulated in manuscript and, seen by John Locke, to have formed part of the doctrine put into the Fourth Book of the *Essay on Human Understanding* (1690). When attention was focused on it, it was pronounced an early work, ante-dating the *Discourse* (1637) by perhaps a full decade; but it showed another Descartes altogether, a Descartes whose primary interest was certainly not in the existence of God and the immortality of the soul but in scientific discovery and its proper method.

Here was a new start for Cartesian studies, and it was taken up by a number of scholars, among them the author of the present *New Studies*, Norman Kemp Smith. In this earlier book, long out of print and which he now calls a 'prentice-work' but which stimulated many generations of students, he gave a clear account of Descartes' logic as it appeared in the *Regulae* and as it affected his philosophy in general. Among other points of importance he showed that the outlook of the *Regulae* involved a *dis*-continuous view of the universe, and thus the Occasionalism which according to the traditional story was an aberration of Descartes' disciples was apparent in the master himself. (Occasionalism is the name given to the theory of those of Descartes' followers who saw that his doctrine of essence is such as to demand the denial of any intrinsic connection between successive states of the world as a whole or between any

single events within it; and since each one is complete and entire in itself, the appearance of causal relations between them is due to the interposition of an external agent, to wit, God.) It is not difficult to show that this theory is both implicit and explicit in Descartes, and Kemp Smith's penultimate chapter on the fate of the Cartesian principles in Hume served to emphasize the presence of what are generally called Humian principles in Descartes. The book was published many years before the appearance of M. Gilson's rich documentation and it was written from another angle altogether; yet it declared roundly that apart from the physics and what depends on it or is illumined by it, Descartes' philosophy remains in conception essentially Scholastic.

4

But the *Regulae* is a fragment and an unauthorized one at that, and so cannot be accepted as a finally valid source for Descartes' considered views. Other inquirers, however, pointed out that the standard texts themselves, when submitted to unprejudiced scrutiny, told the same story. The new Descartes was in fact a very old one. He was to be found not only in the *Regulae*. He reposed in the *Discourse* itself. And he was recognized as such in his own century, as a study of the criticisms of him in Spinoza showed clearly. The 'system' of Descartes was a voluntarism rather than a rationalism, and its difficulties were not met but only concealed in his theology.

More recent work went even further. Since Descartes was what in our day is called a scientist rather than a philosopher, it is a mistake to see the *Meditations* as his typical contribution to thought. He was certainly far from being the abstract intellectualist of the tradition with his eyes fixed on Heaven and the destiny of the soul. If there is any one thing which can be shown, both by the record itself and by contemporary jests, to have held his attention throughout the whole of his adult life, it is, indeed, not the human soul but the human body. He laboured throughout for the realization of a 'marriage between medicine and mathematics' which would offer infallible remedies for physical ills and thus prolong human life indefinitely. But this aim, however praiseworthy, is not abstract and metaphysical. It is practical, even utilitarian. And its criterion is not that of logical consistency but of empirical verification.

The traditional account of Descartes had thus to be revised. The metaphysics was put into its place. And emphasis was laid on that empiricist side of his labours which seems so strangely to have held no interest for the tradition.

5

The importance of Professor Kemp Smith's new volume lies in the fact that it is not content with an adjustment of the traditional

account even as revised and improved. It offers us a fresh Descartes altogether. It is revolutionary because the Descartes it portrays is *in principle* different from that previously accepted. I shall emphasize a few points without, I hope, distorting them.

(i) The Descartes which it offers is not a metaphysician at all; and it suggests that when he tried his hand at metaphysics he did not show himself very successful. When he said that he only spent a few hours of his life at it, he meant what he said. He had a 'one track mind' and was intent on other things.

(ii) Further, he was constantly on the move intellectually. He never stood still. There is no one consistent Descartes even in the books he published himself, and the published works do not contain the whole Descartes. The later books represent an advance on the earlier, and — more importantly — the later *letters* represent an advance on the published books. Indeed, since Descartes inclined to reticence and was not fond of giving himself away, it often happens that an idea which had been in his mind for a long period saw the light only in a letter written in connection with other things, and then often in a casual and incomplete fashion. If we wish to understand Descartes as he really was and thought, we must therefore be often satisfied with incidental hints and allusions. Nor must we be surprised if we are suddenly brought up against fresh ideas. It is just the unexpected which, with such a mind, is significant.

(iii) It follows that we do not deal with established doctrine even in the published writings. There are no fully thought out positions which are fundamental parts of a thoroughly articulated system. There are only improvisations (the word is Professor Kemp Smith's own), preliminary suggestions, as it were, put forward to meet the facts and difficulties facing us, but never meant as more than that. They are in fact hypotheses awaiting revision. What we have been brought up to think as the foundations of Cartesianism become temporary planks in a preliminary scaffolding.

I have perhaps exaggerated in this last paragraph but I do so in order to bring out the novelty of the *New Studies*. Descartes, says Professor Kemp Smith,

was a pioneer, adventuring into territories large tracts of which, even now, three hundred years after his death, are still *terra incognita*. In however confident a spirit he might set out, he could not count on being able to forecast, in any adequate manner, the tasks and dangers ahead, and had therefore no option save to rely on such improvisations as his experience of conditions in the homeland he was leaving qualified him to devise (p. 324).

What were these 'improvisations'? I quote Professor Kemp Smith again, this time from two of the italicized section-headings with which in this, as in other books, he so thoughtfully sustains the reader:

Descartes' first main improvisation: the equating of matter with extension. . . .

Descartes second main improvisation: that mind can be equated with thought, being as exhaustively known in terms of thought as matter is in terms of extension . . . (p. 324)

6

If we consider the central character of these positions in the traditional account of Descartes, what I have called the revolutionary character of the *New Studies* is apparent. A possible view would have been that Descartes did indeed commit himself to these and other positions; that these positions both in themselves and in their consequences proved untenable; and that Descartes himself came to recognize this and to bemoan it without power of finding a remedy. Professor Kemp Smith shows reason to think otherwise. In his view Descartes never put forward these positions as final. When their consequences became apparent, therefore, however stubbornly he fought in their defence, he was always ready to change his front. As a fact he was unprepared with any thought-out substitute. But his mind was constantly at work, and he was constantly dropping hints of possible alternatives and new lines of progress.

A principal scandal in Descartes, as has been noted above, is his apparent Occasionalism. This doctrine is enshrined in his atomistic account of time with its theory of causation as the piling (as it were) of independent slices one on top of another by an external agent. Professor Kemp Smith notes the trend but thinks now that it is 'not among the allowable alternatives' (p. 213). He insists on a later doctrine of motion which involves continuity and hence a time which is real. The student is placed in a dilemma. He is grateful to the author for pointing out these passages and agrees he would like to think that that is the direction in which Descartes was going. But is there any indication that Descartes ever gave up his official account of time? It is to be found in a famous passage in the *Replies to Objections* in intimate connection with Descartes' theology; it is repeated as a plain proposition in the *Principles*. If there are no passages in the later letters or elsewhere specifically repudiating it, what can we make of Descartes' adoption of its very opposite and antithesis, the idea of real continuity involved in the new doctrine of motion? It must be said firmly that Professor Kemp Smith's account of this matter leaves many loose ends, however much the loose ends are Descartes' own.

But it is the direction of the new interpretation which is all important. It asks us to read Descartes more, and to read him both more extensively and more carefully. And it requests our sympathy for a thinker who never pretended to a system but was always going ahead and thinking afresh. Professor Kemp Smith's Descartes, if he had been faced with these texts, would have said, apparently, 'Perhaps I shouldn't have written like that. Certainly I ought not to have said what I did about time. But I've now passed beyond that and you've no right to bring it up against me. I'm concerned now with something much more important; and if I can only work out my ideas on motion, my earlier ill-advised remarks won't need taking back: they'll refute themselves. But please do not disturb me now. Let me go on.'

7

A striking instance of the new light, and the new perplexity, thrown by Professor Kemp Smith's inquiries is what he has to say on the crux of Cartesian interpretation, the problem of the relation of mind and body. The official theory is well summarized in the old saw: 'What is mind? No matter! What is matter? Never mind!' Mind and matter for Descartes are irreducibly distinct, and that means that between soul and body there is and can be no connection.

So the theory; but in practice there is obviously a connection. As a fact we have feelings and perceptions; and whatever the nature of these may be, their very existence shows that in fact body and soul do meet. So Descartes was reduced to advance the famous contrivance of the pineal gland. He asserted that, in that one point of our physiological make-up, mind and body occupy a common ground on which they meet and exchange impressions. Assuming this were true as a fact of experience (and Descartes confesses his failure to substantiate it by observation), it would seem to invalidate the original premise; and conversely, if the original premise were sound, the existence of any meeting place between mind and body would be inconceivable. Yet Descartes, according to the received theory, held fast to both — both the original premise which made the possibility of a meeting-place inconceivable, and the existence of the meeting-place which makes the original premise untrue.

But Professor Kemp Smith points out that as early as 1643 (that is, between the publication of the *Meditations* and the *Principles*) Descartes speaks of the *union* of mind and body as a basic fact. It is a 'notion no less primitive and ultimate than the notion of either taken separately' (p. 258). As far back as the *Regulae* Descartes seems to have thought in terms of an 'embodied self' in which body and soul are one. In the *Meditations* he spoke of their 'intermingling'. But he seems to see now that the 'intermingling' of the two elements

is not enough. There is a primary union between them; and the idea of this primary union is itself as primary as is each of the two ideas of thought and extension themselves! Descartes is clearly moving on. But one may legitimately ask what has become of his starting point. The later Descartes now revealed to us seems not only to have anticipated his critics in their criticisms but in some cases at least to have anticipated their own constructive ideas.

And such indeed is Professor Kemp Smith's expressed view. To the question in what direction Descartes' thought was taking him, he answers: towards Hume and Kant.

The lines in which his thought was moving, in these last years, indicate a tendency to question precisely those postulates which have most decisively influenced the thinking of his immediate successors; and his teaching, on being thus modified, might well have foreshortened the course of history, anticipating and reinforcing certain of the critical elements in the teaching of Hume and Kant (p. 219).

From a great and proven student of both these thinkers this answer is of extreme interest and importance, and a layman's view on it is worth little. Hume and Kant have meant many things to many men, and many of their positions were anticipated by their predecessors. One notes the careful limitation to 'certain elements in' their theory of knowledge for which the claim is made; yet the very mention of their names prompts reflection on the varying types of philosophers and the variety of the legacies they have left behind them.

8

Kant's unique and gigantic contribution would seem to have come from his architectonic power, a power conspicuously absent in Descartes. Hume's genius displayed itself in questions of morals and politics on which Descartes' views were little more than conventional; and however much in theory he was polite to the mathematicians, he notoriously sought, like Kant, to free the practical reason from the embarrassing pretensions of the theoretical. It is Locke, tentative but hardy, the admirer of Sydenham and Boyle, to whom the later Descartes (as indeed is suggested by Professor Kemp Smith) seems most akin; but if this is so, what a reversal of the Descartes of the tradition, and, one might add, of the Descartes of Locke himself.

And yet the scene is well set. It was the later Descartes, we are now told, who refused to identify mind with thought ('every drowsy nod shakes their doctrine, who teach that the soul is always thinking'); the later Descartes who denied the identity of matter with extension (again Locke: 'the extension of body distinguished from

the extension of space'); the later Descartes who recognized degrees in 'clearness and distinctness' and thus upset his own criterion of knowledge and truth. Professor Kemp Smith singles out the Scholastic idea of essence as the root of many of Descartes' metaphysical difficulties, and he quotes passages in which Descartes seems on the brink of rejecting that ever-present bugbear of philosophy. If only Descartes had been spared to build on these anticipations of Locke's remarks on substance and the self, he might well be thought to be on the way of becoming an earlier and more intelligible, although a less schematic, Kant.

But it was not to be, and that for the reason adduced by Professor Kemp Smith. Descartes was not interested in 'pure' thought. He cared for results, practical results in the alleviation of the human burden. At the beginning of his career he showed a profound interest in, and understanding of, the technical problems of optics; at the end he laid the plans for an Academy of Scientists and a School for Artisans. Professor Kemp Smith believes that at the very end (that is, from the point of view of historical knowledge: we should remember that Descartes died unexpectedly at the height of his powers) he was planning the microscope and its application to the problems of embryology and disease. One feels that Descartes' appropriate milieu would have been the Royal Society. One suspects that he was by nature incapable of working with others as equals: his remark on the 'vacuum in Pascal's head' hardly suggests a natural bent for collaboration. Yet who knows to what heights he might have risen even alone if he had been given the patronage which he was always asking for and which — at the end — he had been promised and seemed about to receive.

Yet even so, of the gifts lacking to him one may surely count Kant's patient and penetrative comprehension. Kant was above all the synoptic theorist. He strove to unite the worlds of Rousseau and of Newton; and to ethics and physics he added the realms of art and teleology, of anthropology and religion. One feels that if Professor Kemp Smith is right in his new portrait of Descartes, the world could have had not so much an earlier Kant as a later and soberer Bacon. Suppose Descartes, with the help of his artisans and his academy, had indeed produced a microscope, one wonders whether he might not have spent his remaining years in studying the nature of the pineal gland and seeking empirical verification for the union of mind and body. He might indeed with their help have 'completed his physics as he had hoped' (as he says in a late and significant letter quoted p. 361); but one recalls with melancholy that theories of physics, even of the greatest minds and even when guided by the most delicate instruments, become rapidly and irrevocably out of date.

It is commonly stated that lawyers' own wills are for the most part drawn up irregularly. It is not surprising therefore that the protagonist in modern philosophy of 'clear and distinct ideas' should be at times unclear and indistinct. But genius lies in vision, not in clarity; and we return with relief from the 'scientific philosophy' of today to Descartes' exciting and unverifiable ideas, even though we learn now that these ideas were in his own eyes only improvisations. We are grateful to Professor Kemp Smith for showing us the truth about them, and to the tradition for having missed it; and we shall pause to admire the ripe scholarship with which the fulness of age has matured the pioneer brilliance of youth.